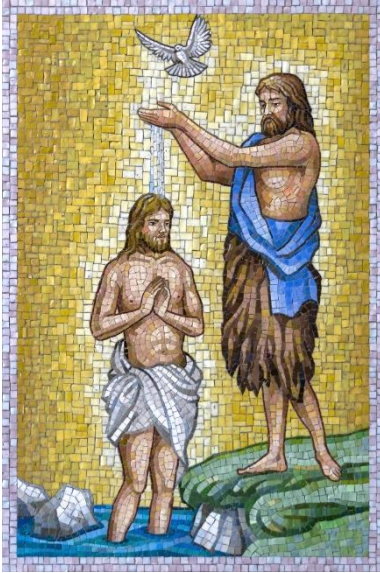


Living Savior Lutheran Church

September 2021 Newsletter

Pastor's Message



Shortly after I graduated from the seminary, an older, neighboring pastor was sharing with me his thoughts on ministry. We were driving from Philadelphia to Buffalo, New York for a conference, and we had a lot of time to talk. He was significantly older than I was, and had a great amount of experience in the life of the church. "To be a successful pastor," he said, "you must be able to pass the "The John the Baptist Test." I was fresh out of the seminary and thought I knew everything — or thought I should know everything - so I nodded in agreement. Then he looked at me slyly, and asked: "You do know what the "John the Baptist Test is, don't you?"

With some embarrassment I had to admit — NO, I had no idea what "The John the Baptist Test" was. "Well, anyway," he continued, "John the Baptist had only one goal uppermost in his mind. Know what it was? It's simply this: John said, "He must increase, but I must decrease". That's John 3:30, in case you are wondering."

I was not wondering about the reference, but just what it meant. "That's the John the Baptist Test" all of us leaders must take and pass," he said. "To not care about any personal praise or criticism too much, but to do all we can to decrease ourselves in order to magnify Christ. We are just sign posts pointing not to ourselves but to him. That's the test that really matters." Those were the best words of advice I have ever received regarding ministry. We are not in the center, rather we are the "sign posts" pointing others to the cross of Jesus Christ.

In 1 Corinthians 4, the apostle Paul writes: "So then, men ought to regard us as servants of Christ and as those entrusted with the secret things of God. [2] Now it is required that those who have been given a trust must prove faithful." Paul is giving the Corinthians and us the "The John the Baptist Test"! He is reminding us that as we do our work in this congregation, we are servants of Christ, stewards who have been honored with tasks, but who, in the end, are still just servants. Our highest concern is that Christ might increase and we decrease, so that the church might increase in its life and work also magnify Christ.

I look forward to the exciting work we have planned together this year, as we seek to increase Christ!

God's peace this month,

Pastor Andrews C. Lissy